

What Are You Becoming?

Aristotle, Character, and AI-Assisted Life

The Apology You Didn't Write

You said something cruel to a friend on Thursday night. By Friday morning you know you have to apologize. You sit down to write the message, and every draft comes out defensive, tangled, half-blaming her for making you feel this way. You open a chatbot instead. You type in what happened, describe how you feel, and ask for an apology that is warm, honest, and takes responsibility. The model gives you three paragraphs. They are clearer, calmer, and kinder than anything you could produce right now. You tweak one line so it sounds more like you, and you send it.

Your friend replies within an hour. She says the apology meant a lot. She feels heard.

Sit with that for a minute. Nothing visibly bad has happened. The message accurately described your feelings. The responsibility-taking was real. The friendship survived. You were probably kinder in text than you could have managed in person while still upset. If ethics is only about outcomes, the case looks straightforward. If ethics is only about obeying a rule, the case still looks fine as long as no one made you promise to write apologies without AI.

Something still feels off. If your friend later learned how the message came together, she might feel managed, handled, processed. You might feel that too, quietly, even if you never tell her. A longer question sits underneath the case. When the next fight happens, will you write the apology yourself, or will you go back to the machine? Ten fights from now, are you still the person who apologizes to her, or has the model gradually become the one who apologizes on your behalf?

Rules and consequences do not settle these questions well. They can tell you whether a specific act was permitted and whether it produced a good result. They have a harder time with what is happening to you across the whole run of small choices, and with what is happening to the friendship as a practiced relationship across time. That is the terrain Aristotle mapped, and it is why he is still in this course.

Who Aristotle Was and Why He Is Still in the Room

Aristotle was a Greek philosopher who worked in the fourth century BCE. He studied at Plato's Academy for about twenty years, then eventually founded his own school, the Lyceum, in Athens. He wrote across almost every field the ancient world recognized as knowledge: logic, physics, biology, poetics, rhetoric, metaphysics, politics, and ethics. His most influential ethical work is the *Nicomachean Ethics*, thought to be a set of lectures compiled by his son (or by an editor) named Nicomachus.



Image: *Aristotle Altemps Inv8575* · After Lysippos.
Public domain. Source:
https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Aristotle_Altemps_Inv8575.jpg.

THINKER IN THE TEXT

Aristotle

384-322 BCE

virtue-ethics guide

Aristotle moves the chapter from isolated AI choices to habits, flourishing, and practical wisdom.



([https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Francesco_rosselli_\(ill.\)%2C_etica_di_aristotele%2C_firenze_1480_ca._\(bnf\)_01.jpg](https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Francesco_rosselli_(ill.)%2C_etica_di_aristotele%2C_firenze_1480_ca._(bnf)_01.jpg))

MANUSCRIPT

Illuminated Renaissance manuscript of Aristotle's Ethics

A Renaissance manuscript of Aristotle's Ethics, Florence, around 1480.

Image: Francesco Bini. CC BY-SA 4.0.

[https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Francesco_rosselli_\(ill.\)%2C_etica_di_aristotele%2C_firenze_1480_ca._\(bnf\)_01.jpg](https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Francesco_rosselli_(ill.)%2C_etica_di_aristotele%2C_firenze_1480_ca._(bnf)_01.jpg)

That biography gets us oriented. Modern political categories such as citizenship, slavery, and gender in ancient Athens sit very awkwardly with the twenty-first century, and this chapter does not import Aristotle's whole social world. The reason to read him now is the practical ethical vocabulary that has held up for more than two thousand years: character, habituation, flourishing, and practical wisdom. He treats ethics as a subject for people who need to act, not for

people who need a proof. He is honest that ethics cannot be as exact as geometry, and that the point of studying it is to become the kind of person who judges and acts well (NE I.3, 1094b (<https://classics.mit.edu/Aristotle/nicomachaen.html>)).

That practical orientation is what makes him useful for a course on AI ethics. When students are working on the AI apology case, or on any digital dilemma where the question is what a pattern of use is doing to them, Aristotle offers concepts that describe the problem more precisely than reflexes like “just follow the rules” or “just weigh the outcomes.” The rest of this chapter unpacks those concepts and shows how they let you build an argument you can defend and revise.

If you want to read Aristotle directly, a public-domain translation by F. H. Peters is available through the Liberty Fund Online Library of Liberty (<https://oll.libertyfund.org/titles/peters-the-nicomachean-ethics>), and W. D. Ross’s translation is at MIT Classics (<https://classics.mit.edu/Aristotle/nicomachaen.html>). For scholarly interpretation, the Stanford Encyclopedia entry on Aristotle’s Ethics (<https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/aristotle-ethics/>) is the standard reference; the broader SEP entry on Virtue Ethics (<https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/ethics-virtue/>) and the Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy entry on Virtue Ethics (<https://iep.utm.edu/virtue/>) are useful supplements.

Flourishing Is a Whole-Life Question

Aristotle opens the *Ethics* with a claim about action. Every activity aims at some good. You cook because you want dinner. You study because you want to pass a class, or because you want to understand something, or because you want to graduate, or because you want a job. You apologize because you want to repair a friendship. Ask why for long enough about any activity, and eventually the answer stops referring to something else. That end-point, the good we want for its own sake, he calls *eudaimonia* (NE I.7, 1097b (<https://classics.mit.edu/Aristotle/nicomachaen.html>)).

Eudaimonia is often translated as “happiness,” and that translation causes trouble. In English, happiness usually means an emotional state: cheerful, satisfied, upbeat. Aristotle is talking about something closer to a life going well as a whole. Flourishing is the word most translators reach for now. A person is flourishing when their life is going well in the sense that their capacities are engaged, their relationships are functioning, their character is stable, and their activities are genuinely worth doing. You cannot flourish in a five-minute window. You can be cheerful in a five-minute window while a whole life is quietly going off the rails.

The AI apology looks different once you make that distinction. If you measure the case by momentary satisfaction, the model-assisted apology probably wins. Both of you feel better within the hour. If you measure it by whether your life as a friend is going well, the answer needs a longer look. The friendship is not the message. The friendship is the pattern of attention, honesty, courage, and repair that runs between you across years. The specific apology landed because it fit into that pattern. The quiet risk is that you become a person who cannot repair a friendship without a machine. An outcome check usually misses that risk. A whole-life frame brings it into view.

Aristotle also insists that *eudaimonia* is active. He describes it as an activity of the soul in accordance with virtue, across a complete life (*NE* I.7, 1098a <https://classics.mit.edu/Aristotle/nicomachaen.html>). You flourish by doing things well, using the capacities that are distinctively yours, in the situations you actually face. A person who is fed, entertained, and untroubled but who never exercises judgment, care, or courage may be comfortable. Aristotle would not describe that life as flourishing, because those capacities remain unused.

Keep that warning close as you work through AI-mediated life. Comfort and outcome quality are real goods. They are not the same as flourishing. A system that reliably produces smoother outputs while quietly eroding your capacity to produce them yourself is trading one kind of good for another, and the trade may not be obvious for a long time.

Key Point: Eudaimonia Is Flourishing, Not a Mood

For Aristotle, *eudaimonia* is a whole life going well through activity that uses your distinctively human capacities. A passing feeling of satisfaction or a good result on one occasion falls short of that standard. When you evaluate an ethical case, ask whether the practice contributes to a life going well over time, and whether it only produced a pleasant moment.

What Human Capacities Are For

If flourishing is activity in accordance with virtue, the next question is what activity we are talking about. Aristotle's answer runs through his function argument. He notices that we recognize excellence for almost anything with a function. A good knife cuts well. A good doctor heals well. A

good flute-player plays well. In each case, “good” means performing the characteristic activity of the thing at a high level. He then asks whether humans have a characteristic activity in this sense (*NE* I.7, 1097b–1098a (<https://classics.mit.edu/Aristotle/nicomachaen.html>)).

The word usually translated as “function” is *ergon*. It does not mean job in a modern occupational sense. It means characteristic work, the activity a thing is fitted to perform. Aristotle’s move is to ask what activity is distinctively human. Growth and nutrition are not, because plants share them. Perception and desire are not, because other animals share them. What remains is rational activity: reasoning about what to do, deliberating, choosing, using language, forming judgments, sharing a life with others through speech and thought.

Aristotle is not saying that humans are only their rationality, that emotions do not count, or that people who reason less are less human. He is saying that if we want to describe what humans do well when we do well, we have to identify the activities that draw on the capacities almost uniquely available to us. Reason is the most obvious. Reasoned relationship, deliberate action, shared judgment, and the ability to hold ourselves accountable follow closely.

The word *telos* names the end or aim toward which those capacities point. Human flourishing is the *telos* of human activity in the same way that health is the *telos* of medicine. Doctors do many things (write charts, order tests, make small talk during appointments), but the work is answerable to health. Humans do many things, but the whole activity is answerable to flourishing.

Applied to the AI apology, this vocabulary changes what you notice. The message repaired the friendship, which is a real good. And the practice of apology draws on capacities that are the *ergon* of a friend: paying attention to how you hurt someone, tolerating the discomfort of admission, forming words that fit both what happened and who you are, choosing a moment to send. If a machine performs all of those steps for you, the outcome may still occur, but the human activity behind it thins out. Aristotle’s framework asks whether your capacities are being exercised or bypassed. Over time, bypassing those capacities can leave a person less able to use them.

One limit needs flagging. The function argument is one of the most disputed pieces of the *Ethics*, and many contemporary philosophers argue that it does not work as a strict logical proof. What survives criticism, and what is actually useful in a philosophy classroom, is the softer version: humans have characteristic capacities, those capacities matter for how our lives go, and living well involves exercising them so they do not wither. You can find a careful review of the argument and its problems in the [SEP entry](https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/aristotle-ethics/#HumaGoodFuncArgu) (<https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/aristotle-ethics/#HumaGoodFuncArgu>).

Practice Becomes Character

Once flourishing is understood as activity of the whole person over a life, the question becomes how such a life develops. Aristotle's answer runs through two related ideas: virtue as a stable disposition, and habituation as the process that forms it.

A virtue, in Aristotle's technical sense, is a settled state of character that inclines you toward certain kinds of action, feeling, and choice. Honesty is a virtue when truth-telling has become a stable feature of the person: they tend to notice when honesty is at stake, feel appropriate discomfort at deception, and choose truthful speech without having to talk themselves into it every time. Courage, generosity, justice, temperance, friendliness, and patience work the same way. A vice is the same kind of stable state pulling in the opposite direction. A dishonest person is not simply someone who lied yesterday. Dishonesty is settled in them, so that lying feels available, expected, easy.

That way of thinking about virtue defends against a common misreading: judging character from one action. A friend who lied to you once is not a liar in Aristotle's sense unless the lie expressed a settled disposition. A friend who tells the truth once under easy conditions is not honest in Aristotle's sense unless honesty is settled in them. Character shows up in patterns of action, not in single snapshots. The same holds for the AI apology. Sending one AI-assisted message does not make you a bad friend, and writing one apology by hand does not make you a good friend. Your character shows up in the pattern of practice underneath the individual choice.

How do stable dispositions form? Aristotle's answer is deceptively plain. He says we become just by doing just acts, temperate by doing temperate acts, and brave by doing brave acts (*NE* II.1, 1103a–b (<https://classics.mit.edu/Aristotle/nicomachaen.html>)). The vocabulary is habituation. We shape our character by what we repeatedly do, especially in the situations that call for the relevant response. A person becomes generous by giving in situations that call for generosity, not by admiring generosity in the abstract. A person becomes honest by telling the truth in situations that make telling it costly, not by valuing honesty on a survey.

Practice becomes character

AI assistance enters a chain of formation; the same output can support or replace a capacity.

01 Repeated action
02 Habit
03 Disposition
04 Character and flourishing

This is where AI-mediated life gets interesting from a virtue-ethics angle. If honesty is trained by repeatedly telling the truth in hard situations, and if the truth-telling is offloaded to a system that composes messages for you, what is being trained? The message may still be honest in the technical sense that its content is accurate. The human capacity to produce honesty under pressure, however, is not being trained. Repetition of the offload trains something else. It builds reliance on the tool, familiarity with its outputs, and a kind of ease that consists of not having to grow.

The same logic runs through many small digital practices. If you rely on autocomplete for every email opening, the practice of opening an email in your own words is not being habituated. If you rely on AI to soften every difficult conversation, the practice of managing difficult conversations without help is not being habituated. If you rely on AI to structure every study session, the practice of designing your own thinking is not being habituated. None of these individually says anything about who you are. Repeated across a semester, a year, or a decade, they are training a character, and it may not be the character you would choose in the abstract.

Aristotle is quick to add that habituation only begins the process. Full virtue also requires choice, understanding, and a stable state of the person choosing ([*NE* II.4, 1105a](#)

(<https://classics.mit.edu/Aristotle/nicomachaen.html>)). You have to do the right thing knowingly, on purpose, and from a settled character. A person who accidentally tells the truth is not honest. A child who tells the truth because a parent is watching is not yet honest in the mature sense. Virtue includes what you do, why you do it, and what you feel while doing it. Habituation is the ground floor, but the building rises further.

Framework Map: Virtue, Vice, Habituation, Phronesis

Virtue

A stable disposition of character that inclines you toward the right action, feeling, and choice in a given kind of situation. Honesty, courage, generosity, and temperance are common examples.

Vice

A stable disposition pulling in the opposite direction. Dishonesty, cowardice, stinginess, and self-indulgence are examples.

Habituation

The process by which repeated action forms character. We become the kind of people who tend to act, feel, and choose in certain ways by practicing those actions, feelings, and choices in the situations that call for them.

Phronesis (practical wisdom)

The capacity to judge what a particular situation actually calls for. Habituation grounds virtue; phronesis steers it. Together they let you respond well to cases that no rule anticipates.

The Mean Is Not Moderation

Aristotle's most famous idea is also his most abused. He argues that virtue is a mean between excess and deficiency. Courage sits between cowardice (too little confidence in danger) and recklessness (too much). Generosity sits between stinginess and wastefulness. Truthfulness sits

between self-deprecation and boastfulness. Friendliness sits between surliness and flattery (*NE* II.6, 1106b–1107a (<https://classics.mit.edu/Aristotle/nicomachaen.html>)).

Read quickly, this becomes “moderation in everything,” which is a very bad summary. Aristotle is explicit that the mean is relative to us and determined by reason, in the way a person with practical wisdom would determine it. That does two things at once. The right response depends on who you are, what the situation is, and what is actually at stake. The wrong response also remains possible. The mean names the fitting response, which may sit close to what looks like an extreme when the situation calls for it.

Think about the AI apology through this lens. One version of AI use looks like deficiency: refusing all help even when your own capacity is temporarily overwhelmed, and sending a raw, hurtful, incoherent message because unassisted expression is the only “authentic” option. Another version looks like excess: outsourcing the entire emotional labor of the apology, sending model-generated warmth without doing any of the human work of noticing what you did or feeling what you owe. The mean is the response that fits this friend, this incident, your actual capacities, and the kind of relationship you are trying to sustain. It might involve using the model to unstick a draft you have already started. It might involve closing the laptop, going for a walk, and writing something rough by hand. “Use AI in moderation” does not answer which one is right. A wise person has to judge the case.

Aristotle underlines this by noting that some actions and passions do not admit a mean at all. Spite, envy, adultery, theft, and murder are not virtuous when done “moderately.” They have no proper amount (*NE* II.6, 1107a (<https://classics.mit.edu/Aristotle/nicomachaen.html>)). The mean applies to responses where excess and deficiency are both possible failures. It does not apply where the action itself is already a failure. That guardrail keeps virtue ethics from turning into “everything in balance,” which would license almost anything if you did enough of the opposite to compensate.

Two implications matter for how you use this framework in PHIL 123. First, when you are analyzing a case, do not settle for saying the answer is “somewhere in the middle.” That is the moderation misreading, and it will not carry a virtue-ethics argument. You have to say what the fitting response is for the particular case, given the person, situation, and stakes. Second, when you are trying to identify a vice, ask whether the practice tips toward excess or deficiency of some real human good. Excessive reliance on AI for personal communication may deform sincerity and courage. Deficient willingness to use AI for study or accessibility may reflect a false pride that harms your own learning. Neither answer is obvious in advance. Each has to be judged.

Caution: The Golden Mean Is Not Automatic Moderation

Aristotle's mean is the fitting response for the situation, relative to the agent, as a person of practical wisdom would judge it. It names a practical judgment, not the arithmetic middle of two extremes or "a little of everything." Some actions have no virtuous middle. A virtue-ethics argument that concludes "the answer is somewhere in between" without saying what the fitting response actually is has not finished its work.

Phronesis and the Judgment No Rule Can Do for You

If the mean is relative to the situation, someone has to judge the situation. Aristotle calls that capacity *phronesis*, usually translated as practical wisdom. It is different from *sophia*, theoretical wisdom about eternal or necessary things such as mathematics, and different from *techné*, technical skill in producing an object. *Phronesis* concerns action about human goods in variable situations, where the case can go many ways and the right response is not deducible from a formula (*NE* VI.5, 1140a–b (<https://classics.mit.edu/Aristotle/nicomachaen.html>)).



(https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Aristotle%2C_Nicomachean_Ethics%2C_Book_6.jpg)

MANUSCRIPT

Nicomachean Ethics, Book VI manuscript

Book VI of Aristotle's Nicomachean Ethics in a late-fifteenth-century Greek manuscript.

Image: Aristotle. Public domain. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Aristotle%2C_Nicomachean_Ethics%2C_Book_6.jpg

A practically wise person has three connected capacities. They see the salient features of a situation, including features a rule would miss. They deliberate well about what a good response would look like. And they choose, in the moment, an action that fits what they saw and reasoned through. Aristotle emphasizes that the wise person is oriented toward the human good as a whole, not toward a specific goal in isolation (*NE VI.5*, 1140a–b (<https://classics.mit.edu/Aristotle/nicomachaen.html>)).

Someone who is clever at hitting narrow targets, without a view of what is worth targeting, has *deinotes* (cleverness), not *phronesis*.

Practical wisdom concerns particulars (NE VI.7–8, 1141b–1142a

(<https://classics.mit.edu/Aristotle/nicomachaen.html>)). This is the point most relevant to AI-mediated life. A rule can tell you that honesty matters. It cannot tell you whether this apology, to this friend, after this specific fight, calls for a hand-written note or a phone call or a message in her preferred medium. A framework can tell you that sincerity is a virtue. It cannot tell you whether this level of AI assistance in this message, given how you two have communicated for the past three years, counts as sincerity supported or sincerity replaced. The judgment lives at the level of the particular. And it has to be your judgment, because you are the one who knows the friend and the fight.

That is where the AI apology becomes hardest, and most interesting, as a philosophical case. The model can help you produce a good sentence. It cannot decide for you whether a sentence is what this moment calls for. It cannot notice that your friend responds better to a voice memo than to text. It cannot know that the two of you have a running joke you can invoke at the end to signal that things are okay again. It cannot see the whole relationship from inside. Even if it could produce a message that hits all those notes correctly by pattern-matching from your past messages, the choice to send that message, in that form, at that time, is a judgment about what your friendship needs. That judgment is *phronesis*, and it does not delegate cleanly.

Models may nevertheless show real facility with moral reasoning. Seth Lazar's overview of recent research (<https://blog.cosmos-institute.org/p/the-construction-of-moral-character>) argues that frontier models can often identify morally relevant features and construct sophisticated arguments in text-based cases. Aristotle gives us a reason to distinguish that facility from virtue. Producing a good moral analysis is not the same as possessing a stable disposition, choosing for the right reasons, and acting well across a life.

This gives you a way to distinguish the useful AI-assist cases from the corrosive ones. Practical wisdom is compatible with using tools that help you notice, deliberate, and choose more clearly. It is threatened by tools that let you skip the noticing, the deliberating, or the choosing. A person who talks through a difficult message with a friend, a therapist, or a chatbot in order to see the situation more clearly is still doing the ethical work. A person who lets the tool decide what the situation is has quietly handed over the part of the process that only they can do.

Aristotle also insists that *phronesis* cannot fully be separated from virtue. A person deeply attached to bad ends will not see situations well, because their attention is bent by what they want (NE VI.12, 1144a (<https://classics.mit.edu/Aristotle/nicomachaen.html>)). A cruel person may be clever at manipulation, but they will not judge friendship well because they do not care about friendship. Virtue keeps the perceptions of the wise person tuned to the real human goods, and practical wisdom lets those perceptions guide action. The two travel together.

Pressure, Ignorance, and Being Responsible for What You Become

Aristotle spends a whole book of the *Ethics* on the conditions under which an action counts as voluntary (NE III.1–5, 1109b–1114b (<https://classics.mit.edu/Aristotle/nicomachaen.html>)). This section is often overlooked, and it is one of the most useful parts of his ethics for talking about digital dilemmas. He distinguishes voluntary from involuntary and mixed cases. Actions done under force or through ignorance of specific circumstances count as involuntary. A sailor who throws cargo overboard to save the ship in a storm is in a mixed case: the action is voluntary in the moment, because the sailor chose to do it, and yet no one would ordinarily choose it. Aristotle takes such cases seriously without collapsing them into pure excuses (NE III.1, 1110a (<https://classics.mit.edu/Aristotle/nicomachaen.html>)).

Aristotle's distinction between voluntary, involuntary, and mixed action helps explain how students experience AI-mediated life under pressure. Consider the assignment due in an hour. You did not budget your time well, your job ran late, and you are staring at a blank document. You use AI to complete the assignment. In the moment, the choice is voluntary. You could have accepted a lower grade or a missing submission. And yet the pressure is real, the alternatives feel bad, and the choice is not the free deliberation of someone with the whole afternoon. Aristotle's framework lets you take the pressure seriously as a mitigating condition while still calling the choice yours.

He also distinguishes ignorance of specific circumstances (which can excuse) from ignorance of what is right (which usually cannot). A person who pours a poisoned drink while believing it is harmless lacks the relevant knowledge of the circumstance. A person who treats dishonesty as acceptable lacks moral formation, and Aristotle treats that ignorance as culpable in a mature agent. He uses a memorable image: a drunk person who breaks something is responsible, because they were responsible for getting drunk (NE III.5, 1113b–1114a

(<https://classics.mit.edu/Aristotle/nicomachaen.html>)). Character formed through your own repeated choices is your responsibility even when it now inclines you toward bad action.

This claim cuts directly into digital life. If you have habituated yourself into a state where you cannot write a personal message without a chatbot, cannot read an assignment without a summarizer, cannot sit through a difficult conversation without checking your phone, the state is yours. Aristotle would say you are responsible for the individual action you now find easy and for the earlier practices that made it easy. The wine was poured over many nights. You cannot say now that the drunk person is a different person. In another passage he puts it plainly: it is in our power to become good or bad, and the person who is now unjust or intemperate could have avoided becoming that way, though once formed, the character does not simply unmake itself (NE III.5, 1114a (<https://classics.mit.edu/Aristotle/nicomachaen.html>)).

The same claim has a hopeful side. If character is formed by repeated action, character can be reformed by repeated action. It is slow, uncomfortable, and often awkward, and Aristotle is realistic about how far along a life it is possible. Someone deeply habituated into cowardice does not become brave by reading about courage. They become braver by doing braver things in situations that scare them, again and again, until courage settles in. The same is true of practices around AI use. If you notice that a pattern has formed you into someone you did not intend to become, the remedy is not shame. It is the slow work of practicing the alternative in situations where it costs you.

Building an Argument in Virtue Ethics

You can now build a virtue-ethics argument about a digital or AI dilemma. A defensible argument runs like this:

P1. A repeated action or practice is ethically better when it expresses and cultivates virtues needed for flourishing, and ethically worse when it cultivates vice or weakens practical wisdom.

P2. Repeatedly using AI in this way, in this kind of situation, cultivates [name the specific virtue or vice] because [give a case-specific reason].

C. Therefore, from a virtue-ethics perspective, this practice is [ethically justified / ethically risky / requires revision along these lines].

A well-built argument in this form does three things at once. It names a specific virtue or vice. It evaluates the *practice* across repeated action, which respects Aristotle's emphasis on habituation. And it gives a case-specific reason grounded in what the repeated pattern is training in the agent.

Worked Argument: The AI-Assisted Apology

P1. A repeated action or practice is ethically better when it expresses and cultivates virtues needed for flourishing, and ethically worse when it cultivates vice or weakens practical wisdom.

P2. Repeatedly using AI to compose apologies to close friends cultivates a subtle deficiency in sincerity, because sincerity in intimate friendship requires that the effort of expression come from the person apologizing, not from a tool used to bypass that effort.

C. Therefore, repeatedly outsourcing apologies in intimate relationships is ethically risky, though AI assistance may be defensible in transactional apologies where the goods of friendship are not in play.

Notice what that conclusion does. It is specific to the practice, it distinguishes cases where the same tool has different ethical weight, and it identifies a virtue at stake that a rule-based analysis would miss.

The same argument structure can evaluate any repeated digital practice, from AI-assisted apologies to location tracking. In each case, the strongest arguments will resist two temptations: they will avoid the moderation reading of the mean, and they will avoid inferring settled character from one action. They will instead name what a pattern of use trains, and evaluate the practice on that basis.

Argument Template: Virtue Ethics P1/P2/C

P1

A repeated action or practice is ethically better when it expresses and cultivates virtues needed for flourishing, and ethically worse when it cultivates vice or weakens practical wisdom.

P2

Repeatedly using [technology or practice] in [context] cultivates [name a specific virtue or vice] because [case-specific reason].

C

Therefore, from a virtue-ethics perspective, this practice is [ethically justified / ethically risky / requires revision along these lines].

Limits and Objections

Every ethical framework has weaknesses, and a virtue-ethics argument needs to name the vulnerability in its own reasoning. Four objections recur often enough in the literature that you should be able to state and answer each one.

The first is the **action-guidance objection**. Critics ask whether virtue ethics actually tells you what to do in specific cases. Consequentialism at least tells you to calculate expected outcomes. Deontology at least tells you to check whether the action can be universalized or whether it uses persons as mere means. Virtue ethics tells you to do what a person of practical wisdom would do. That looks circular, or at least unhelpful when you are the one who has to decide. The SEP entry on Virtue Ethics (<https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/ethics-virtue/>) traces the debate in detail. The strongest reply concedes that virtue ethics gives orienting judgment, not mechanical verdicts. Real cases do not have algorithmic answers. Virtue ethics offers a set of orienting questions (what does this situation ask of a person of good character? what virtue is under pressure here? what would practical wisdom notice?) that support judgment without pretending to replace it. When you write your argument, admit this honestly. Do not overpromise a verdict the framework does not deliver.

The second is the **circularity objection**. If virtue is what the person of practical wisdom possesses, and the person of practical wisdom is defined as the person who has virtue, the account looks like it goes in a circle. This concern is closely related to the first. The best replies point out that Aristotle does not build his account only on the wise person. He also builds it on the recognizable list of virtues and vices, the function argument, and the empirical observation that certain practices form certain characters. The wise person is a regulative idea, not the whole justification. You can also point out that most ethical frameworks eventually anchor in something similar. Consequentialism has to say what counts as a good outcome. Deontology has to say what counts as a rational agent. No framework escapes an anchor point somewhere.

The third is **moral luck**. Aristotle himself worries that flourishing depends on external goods that are not fully under our control (*NE* I.10, 1100a–1101a

<https://classics.mit.edu/Aristotle/nicomachaen.html>). Health, family, friends, freedom from war, access to education, and enough resources to act well all matter. Two people with identical characters can end up with very different lives if one is born into war and the other into peace. A more contemporary version notes that character formation itself depends on luck: the family you were born into, the neighborhood, the school, the early relationships. If people cannot fully choose their character, holding them responsible for it looks harsh. The [Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy](https://iep.utm.edu/virtue/) entry on *Virtue Ethics* (<https://iep.utm.edu/virtue/>) discusses this well. The honest reply is to accept the difficulty. Virtue ethics does not claim that flourishing is fully self-made, and Aristotle is more realistic about luck than his caricature suggests. Within whatever conditions we have, the framework insists that the practices we choose still form us, and those practices carry real ethical weight.

The fourth is the **self-centeredness objection**. Critics worry that virtue ethics focuses so much on what practices form the agent that it can look like a project of self-improvement. If the reason you should tell the truth is that it makes you the kind of person you want to be, the concern is that other people become props in your character-building project. The reply, put most clearly in modern virtue ethics literature such as the [SEP entry](https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/ethics-virtue/) (<https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/ethics-virtue/>), is that many virtues are essentially other-directed. Justice, friendship, generosity, care, and honesty cannot be practiced without genuinely orienting toward other people. A person who “helps” others only to build their own resume is performing resume management in generous clothing. Still, this objection has bite when your argument leans heavily on what a practice does to the agent. Add a sentence about what the practice does to the friend, the community, or the wider set of stakeholders. That balances the account.

None of these objections destroys the framework. Each one identifies a real limit or a place where the argument can be misused. A strong virtue-ethics argument states the objection you consider most dangerous to your own case, and gives a genuine reply. Weak arguments pick a soft objection they can easily dismiss. Do not do that. Pick the one that scares you the most, and respond honestly.

Virtue Ethics, Divine Command Theory, and Natural Law

Comparing virtue ethics with divine command theory and natural law reasoning requires precision about what the frameworks are actually doing when they look at the same case.

Divine command theory asks what grounds moral obligation. Its answer is that God's commands ground it. What makes an action obligatory is that God commands it; what makes an action forbidden is that God forbids it. The framework's central question is about the source of moral authority, and it locates that source outside human character and human deliberation. Different versions of DCT handle the Euthyphro problem differently and connect the divine will to human reason in different ways, but the core move is a grounding move.

Natural law reasoning also concerns grounding, though it takes a different route. Human reason participates in a natural moral order (a set of goods that reason can recognize as goods for human beings), and moral obligations follow from that participation. This is why natural law arguments so often trade in claims about what humans are for, what goods are natural to them, and what reason can discover about how to pursue those goods.

Virtue ethics asks a different question. It does not primarily ask what grounds an obligation. It asks what kind of person and what kind of practice are being formed. When it looks at the AI apology, it does not begin by asking whether God has commanded honesty or whether reason recognizes sincerity as a natural human good. Both of those may be true and may support the case, but the framework's own question is about character, habituation, and flourishing. What virtue is in play? What is the practice training? Does the pattern cultivate practical wisdom or erode it? Is this the kind of activity a life going well would include?

That difference in question is why the three frameworks can appear to agree on a verdict while reaching it through different lines of reasoning. All three might agree that repeatedly outsourcing personal apologies to a chatbot is ethically risky in close friendships. DCT would ground the risk in a divine command about honesty or love of neighbor. Natural law would ground it in the

natural goods of friendship and truthful speech. Virtue ethics would ground it in the character being formed by the practice and in the erosion of the *phronesis* required to sustain an intimate relationship. Do not blur these into one voice. Let each framework reason from its own central concern. A real comparison can then say more precisely what virtue ethics catches that the others do not, and what the others catch that virtue ethics can miss.

Try It: What Habit Is This Technology Training?

Pick one digital or AI-mediated practice you use several times a week. In a few sentences, answer these questions:

1. Which human capacity or virtue is under pressure when you use this technology (for example, sincerity, patience, honesty, attention, self-control, courage, care)?
2. What repeated action does this technology train in you? What is it letting you skip?
3. Does the pattern tip toward excess, deficiency, or a fitting response for the situations where you use it?
4. Write one virtue-ethics P1/P2/C argument about the practice. Name the vulnerability in your own argument in one sentence.

You are not solving the case here. You are seeing what virtue ethics helps you notice about it.

Reading Aristotle Directly

If any of this framework grabbed you, read the primary text. The most-cited passages for this chapter are in Books I, II, III, and VI of the *Nicomachean Ethics*. Book I develops eudaimonia and the function argument. Book II lays out virtue as a stable disposition, habituation, and the mean. Book III handles voluntary action and responsibility. Book VI develops *phronesis*. A public-domain translation by F. H. Peters is available through the [Liberty Fund Online Library of Liberty](https://oll.libertyfund.org/titles/peters-the-nicomachean-ethics) (<https://oll.libertyfund.org/titles/peters-the-nicomachean-ethics>), and W. D. Ross's public-domain translation is at [MIT Classics](https://classics.mit.edu/Aristotle/nicomachaen.html) (<https://classics.mit.edu/Aristotle/nicomachaen.html>).

For scholarly interpretation, the [Stanford Encyclopedia entry on Aristotle's Ethics](https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/aristotle-ethics/) (<https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/aristotle-ethics/>) is the standard reference and traces the debates around the

function argument, the mean, and *phronesis* in more depth than a chapter like this one can. The [SEP entry on Virtue Ethics](https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/ethics-virtue/) (<https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/ethics-virtue/>) situates Aristotle in the modern revival of virtue ethics and canvasses the main objections. The [Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy entry on Virtue Ethics](https://iep.utm.edu/virtue/) (<https://iep.utm.edu/virtue/>) is a more accessible overview and is especially useful for the moral-luck and action-guidance debates.

A virtue-ethics argument does not need any of these secondary sources. It needs a clear, specific claim about what practice is being formed in a digital case you care about, an argument in the P1/P2/C form that ties the evaluation to a named virtue or vice, and an honest statement of the strongest objection your argument has to answer. Aristotle can give you that vocabulary. Whether the practice you are analyzing is training the kind of person you actually want to become is a judgment only you can make about your own life.

References

- Aristotle. *The Nicomachean Ethics* (<https://oll.libertyfund.org/titles/peters-the-nicomachean-ethics>). Translated by F. H. Peters, 5th ed., Kegan Paul, Trench, Trubner & Co., 1893. Online Library of Liberty.
- Aristotle. *Nicomachean Ethics* (<https://classics.mit.edu/Aristotle/nicomachaen.html>). Translated by W. D. Ross. The Internet Classics Archive, Massachusetts Institute of Technology.
- Athanassoulis, Nafsika. “Virtue Ethics.” (<https://iep.utm.edu/virtue/>) *Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy*.
- Hursthouse, Rosalind, and Glen Pettigrove. “Virtue Ethics.” (<https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/ethics-virtue/>) *The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, substantive revision 2026.
- Kraut, Richard. “Aristotle’s Ethics.” (<https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/aristotle-ethics/>) *The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, substantive revision 2022.
- Lazar, Seth. “Are Frontier Models Good at Ethics? The Construction of Moral Character in LLMs.” (<https://blog.cosmos-institute.org/p/the-construction-of-moral-character>) *Cosmos Institute*, July 10, 2026.

← Commands, Constitutions, and Alignment: Natural Law in the AI Alignment Conversation

Practical Wisdom After Aristotle: Vallor, Askill, and the Problem of Machine Judgment →